

VALIANT VALORANT

As the game completed five years, Riot Games **organised a campaign** named V5 to celebrate players from South Asia, who comprise over five million of VALORANT's gamer base.

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First-person shooting (FPS) games in India broke the ice with Counter-Strike 1.6. The navigation around Dust II and Inferno created a buzz like no other in the early 2000s.

Youngsters packed cybercafes, gaming parlours counted currency notes as the gaming industry ballooned in the country.

Eventually, PUBG [PlayerUnknown Battlegrounds] arrived, creating another avenue for battle royale games in the Indian market. Thanks to the 4G boom after 2016, serious gaming no longer remained sequestered on laptops, PCs and PlayStations, spiralling into mobile phones and tablets.

With over 17 million users in the esports industry, the obvious question was, what more can come out of this avenue?

It was then that Riot Games, the developer of League of Legends, came up with VALORANT in 2020 – an FPS that bridged the gap between the style of play of Counter-Strike (precision shooting) and Overwatch

(arcade-based game with characters having unique abilities).

India at that time was reeling from a PUBG ban; the government had banned the game, citing security concerns.

The gap for gamers and esports enthusiasts was quickly filled by VALORANT, which revived PC gaming again. Cyber cafes, which were slowly getting emptier with the rise of mobile gaming, saw people get back together. The archetype of a gamer — a nerd sitting alone and playing with a controller – was shattered. Valorant became a game with the added flavour of community bonding.

"It's a great ecosystem. Riot is a great partner, and it's a very simple zero-to-hero story. The Challenger Series in India right now is the most-watched Challenger Series in the world," Akshat Rathee (right), the founder of NODWIN Gaming, tells



VALORANT INDIA RANKINGS



ABHIRUP
"LIGHTNINGFAST" CHOUDHURY



VENKATESH
"VENKA" SHARMA



YUVAJ
"YUVI" SINGH



RISHI
"RVK" VIJAYAKUMAR



VISHWARATN
"LILBOII" SRIVASTAV

